

English plural -s vs. Spanish plural -s*

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1.

Both English and Spanish have a pronounced plural morpheme that is in general -s. As is well-known, English has irregular plurals such as *people*, *children*, *men*, *women*, *oxen*. Spanish is strikingly different from English in this respect:

(1) Spanish has no irregular plurals ending in a segment different from -s.¹

Put another way, Spanish has the following property:

(2) If there is a pronounced nominal plural morpheme in Spanish, that morpheme is invariably -s.

That is, Spanish has no plurals of the *people*, *men*, *children*, *women*, *oxen*... sort.

Why should English and Spanish differ in this way? In line with comparative syntax work, we will not look toward the logically possible, yet insufficiently ambitious, answer of the 'That's just how it is' sort. Instead, we can and must ask what other differential properties of English and Spanish the above fact about plurals might be related to.

2.

What comes initially to mind is the fact that English plural -s is typically absent in deverbal compounds such as:

(3) Mary is an avid magazine(*s)-reader.

as opposed to the non-compound:

(4) Mary is an avid reader of magazine*(s).

Such compounds have no word-for-word counterparts in Spanish (whose compounds of the V-N type have no missing plural -s). If we take this English/Spanish contrast concerning compounds to be closely related to the earlier one concerning plurals, we are led to the conclusion that an English irregular plural like *children* must be part of a compound.

More specifically, we are led to the possibility that *children* (and the same for other such English plurals) must be analyzed as a compound as follows (capitals indicate silence):

(5) children-BEINGS

with the silence of BEINGS licensed by a plural selectional feature on *children*, in a way akin to how a feature of English *few* licenses silent NUMBER (as in Kayne 2005), and with the licenser (*children*) asymmetrically c-commanding the licensee. In this way, we reduce the absence of -s in *children* to the absence of -s in (3).

3.

At the same time, we account for the fact that Spanish lacks plurals comparable to *children* in terms of the fact that Spanish lacks compounds of the (3) sort, the

¹Or -es; I'm also setting aside here the voicing assimilation found in English.

assumption being that a compound of the sort seen in (5) is the only way in which English and Spanish could possibly reach an irregular plural like *children*. This leads in turn to the following conjecture:

(6) Irregular plurals of the *children* sort involve a silent nominal, in all languages.

Other languages will of course need to be examined in future work, keeping in mind that (6) leads to thinking that English *-en* is not a plural suffix in the same sense as *-s* (for detailed discussion, v. Collins and Kayne 2023, sect. 4.4).

4.

The key idea, namely that plurals like *children* are compounds part of which is silent, has been presented using (3) as a relevant type of compound. Yet there is another type of compound in English that may in fact be closer to *children*, and that shows the key property of the obligatory absence of plural *-s*:²

(7) What made you invite all those linguist persons?

(8) *What made you invite all those linguists persons?

with the absence of *-s* in (7) arguably of the same ilk as its absence in (3).

Of importance is the fact that the closest Spanish counterpart of (7), as given in (9), acts differently from English with respect to *-s*:

(9) ¿Qué te hizo invitar a esas personas lingüistas? ('what you made invite to those persons linguists')

insofar as dropping the *-s* on *lingüistas* in Spanish is not at all possible.

Thus, thinking of *children* as lacking *-s* in exactly the same way that *linguist* lacks *-s* in the compound in (7) allows reducing the absence of an irregular plural like *children* in Spanish to the impossible absence of *-s* in Spanish in (9), with *children* now to be understood, parallel to (7), as:

(10) children PERSONS

5.

A reviewer notes the existence in Spanish of compounds such as:

(11) coche cama ('car bed' = 'sleeping car' = 'bed-car')

whose plural is:

(12) coches cama

in which *cama* has no plural *-s*, much as in English:

(13) Bed(*s)-cars are usually quite comfortable.

This point of similarity between English and Spanish leads us to conclude that the kind of compound that *children* is traceable back to, as in (7) and (10), is quite distinct from that of (13), so that the Spanish examples in (11) and (12), while of interest in their own right, are not directly relevant to the absence in Spanish of irregular plurals such as *children*. The difference may be that compounds of the (11) and (12) type contain a silent preposition (that is not present in (7) and (10)):

(14) coche(s) P cama

²Both this English example and its Spanish counterpart seem best if taken to express a negative emotion like sarcasm (in English, with strong stress on *linguist*).

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References:

Collins, C. and R.S. Kayne (2023) “Towards a Theory of Morphology as Syntax,”
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